

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Developments in Philosophy - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Developments in Philosophy	
REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION - BACKCORE FIRST	
01 SCOPE, CHRONOLOGY AND EVIDENCE DISCIPLINE Repository serves first consulted	02 WHAT COUNTED AS PHILOSOPHY: DARSHANA, ANVIKSHI AND AN ARGUMENTATIVE Technically, what counted as philosophy: darshana, anviki and an
03 VEDIC BACKGROUND: RTA, SACRIFICE AND SPECULATIVE QUESTIONING Technically, Vedic background: no sacrifice and speculative	04 UPANISHADIC DEVELOPMENTS: BRAHMAN, ATMAN, KARMA, REBIRTH AND RELEASE Upanishadic thought on consciousness plus dharma, not just
05 SHRAMANA MILIEU AND THE SECOND URBANISATION The shramana challenge is historically crucial because it made the	06 BUDDHISM: EARLY CONCEPTUAL CORE AND PHILOSOPHICAL ORIENTATION The four noble truths and eightfold path are best treated here as
07 BUDDHISM AFTER THE EARLY CANON: ABHIDHARMA, MAHAYANA, MADHYAMAKA, Mahayana is best taught as a historically cumulative expansion, not a	08 JAIN PHILOSOPHY: JIVA, KARMIC BONDAGE, ANEKANTAVADA, SYADVADA AND ETHICS The Jaina contribution to Indian philosophy is twofold: a rigorous
09 AJIVIKAS: NIYATI, ASCETICISM AND THE HOSTILE-SOURCE PROBLEM Ajivikas were a distinct shramana current associated in hostile	10 LOKAYATA / CHARVAKA, MATERIALISM AND SCEPTICAL CRITIQUE Lokayata means something like "that which is found among people,"
11 ASTIKA, NASTIKA AND THE LATE DOXOGRAPHY PROBLEM Astika / nastika is not a simple God / no-God opposition	12 SAMKHYA: PURUSHA, PRAKRITI, GUNAS AND REAL TRANSFORMATION Is one teaching (sargopadesha) possible (between-consciousness) from
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21 DEBATE INSTITUTIONS, TRANSMISSION AND PATRONAGE Institutions matter because they explain how ideas persisted,	22 ETHICS, LIBERATION, PLURALISM, HISTORIOGRAPHY AND OWNER BOUNDARIES A doctrine of atma, liberation or equality does not prove uniform
23 BOUNDED LIVE LINKAGE Technically, bounded live linkage is analysed by relating The UK India	

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Developments in Philosophy - Complete Topic Package

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQ 01

The safest translation of darshana in the context of ancient Indian philosophy is:

- A. view or way of seeing
- B. ritual tax
- C. monastery revenue code
- D. military ordinance

Answer: A. Darshana literally means "view." It points to a philosophical standpoint or way of seeing reality, not simply to a later list of schools.

Learning MCQ 02

Kautilya's use of anviksiki is most useful for Topic 24 because it shows that:

- A. the Vedas were rejected by the state
- B. inquiry was recognised as a distinct knowledge-branch
- C. all philosophy was anti-state
- D. Buddhist logic already dominated Mauryan courts

Answer: B. The fourfold classification around anviksiki, trayi, varta and dandaniti shows inquiry as a named branch of learning, though the text itself is chronologically layered.

Learning MCQ 03

Which statement about the Nasadiya Sukta is safest?

- A. It proves that Vedic religion rejected sacrifice.
- B. It is a finished Charvaka manifesto.
- C. It preserves speculative questioning and epistemic restraint about creation.
- D. It is the earliest full Vedanta commentary.

Answer: C. The hymn is valuable because it shows questioning, not because it already contains a complete later school.

Learning MCQ 04

Early Upanishads are best described as:

- A. manuals of temple construction
- B. Jain Agamas
- C. post-Puranic sectarian texts
- D. part of the Vedic corpus that redirects attention toward knowledge and self

Answer: D. They remain within shruti while transforming the centre of gravity from ritual explanation toward philosophical interiorisation.

Learning MCQ 05

The most accurate statement about the "second urbanisation" is:

- A. It enabled wider debate and patronage, but does not mechanically explain every doctrine.
- B. It automatically produced Buddhism and Jainism as identical protest movements.
- C. It proves philosophy was only an economic reflex.
- D. It ended all sacrificial traditions immediately.

Answer: A. The context mattered greatly, but doctrinal content still needs its own intellectual history.

Learning MCQ 06

The early Buddhist doctrine of anatman most directly denies:

- A. all worldly suffering
- B. a permanent independent self
- C. karma
- D. ethical effort

Answer: B. Non-self attacks the idea of an enduring self-substance; it does not deny conventional life or moral effort.

Learning MCQ 07

Which statement about Madhyamaka is safest?

- A. It teaches pure fate.
- B. It is a Jaina doctrine of many-sidedness.
- C. It argues that things lack inherent self-existing essence.
- D. It teaches the worship of one creator deity.

Answer: C. Emptiness in Madhyamaka means lack of independent inherent existence, not annihilation or nihilism.

Learning MCQ 08

The best one-line description of Jaina anekantavada is:

- A. all contradictory statements are equally correct
- B. nothing is true
- C. only monastic life is valid
- D. reality is many-sided and cannot be exhausted by one absolute statement

Answer: D. It is a doctrine of many-sided reality, not a surrender of truth.

Learning MCQ 09

The strongest secure Ajivika anchor is:

- A. niyati in hostile sources plus inscriptional patronage markers
- B. Upanishadic authorship
- C. a complete surviving canonical corpus
- D. direct ownership of Nalanda

Answer: A. Ajivika history is thin, but niyati and Mauryan cave patronage give real though limited anchors.

Learning MCQ 10

Which is the safest Charvaka statement?

- A. It survives through a full founder-text.
- B. It privileges perception and rejects many unseen ritual or afterlife claims.
- C. It accepts Vedic ritual as final authority.
- D. It is one of the six orthodox systems.

Answer: B. Charvaka is preserved largely through opponents and is most securely associated with perceptual materialism and anti-ritual critique.

Learning MCQ 11

Why is astika = theist an unsafe shortcut?

- A. because Samkhya and Mimamsa are modern ideologies
- B. because Buddhists accepted the Veda
- C. because historical criteria include Vedic authority or other-world assumptions, not simply belief in God
- D. because the words never appear in any source

Answer: C. The classification is historical and polemical; theism alone is too blunt.

Learning MCQ 12

Samkhya is best remembered in Topic 24 for:

- A. medieval temple ritual
- B. one universal soul identical with all reality
- C. bhakti to a personal god
- D. purusha-prakriti dualism and satkaryavada

Answer: D. Samkhya gives a major dualist cosmology with real transformation of prakriti.

Learning MCQ 13

Citta-vritti-nirodha belongs most directly to:

- A. Yoga
- B. Ajivika
- C. Vaisheshika
- D. Charvaka

Answer: A. It is the classic Yoga formulation of mind-discipline and the path to experiential release.

Learning MCQ 14

The five-member inference is most strongly associated with:

- A. Jaina canon
- B. Nyaya
- C. Vedanta
- D. Mimamsa

Answer: B. Nyaya formalises public reasoning through pramanas, doubt and inferential structure.

Learning MCQ 15

Which pair is correctly matched?

- A. Yoga - atomism
- B. Vedanta - only political economy
- C. Mimamsa - Vedic injunction and ritual hermeneutics
- D. Vaisheshika - temple bhakti

Answer: C. Mimamsa is the school of Vedic interpretation and dharma-centred ritual exegesis.

Learning MCQ 16

The safest final line for a GS-I answer on ancient Indian philosophy is:

- A. philosophy had no relation to institutions
- B. all schools said the same thing
- C. only spirituality mattered
- D. ancient India developed a plural argumentative civilisation sustained by debate, texts and patronage

Answer: D. That conclusion captures plurality, institutions and historical significance without forcing sameness.

Workbook MCQ 01

The safest meaning of dar shana in ancient Indian philosophy is:

- A. a view or way of seeing reality
- B. a temple-tax assessment
- C. a grammatical accent mark
- D. a dynastic genealogy

Answer: A. Dar shana literally means view. It is best handled as a philosophical standpoint rather than as a mere exam list.

Workbook MCQ 02

In the Arthashastra tradition, anviksiki is placed alongside:

- A. bhakti, tantra and temple ritual
- B. trayi, varta and dandaniti
- C. sculpture, painting and dance
- D. Ayurveda, music and drama

Answer: B. The classification marks inquiry as a distinct knowledge-branch next to Vedic learning, economic activity and governance.

Workbook MCQ 03

The safest reading of the Nasadiya Sukta is that it:

- A. is a complete Ajivika text on fate
- B. abolishes sacrifice in the Vedic world
- C. preserves speculative questioning about creation without becoming a finished later school
- D. proves the later Vedanta doctrine of maya

Answer: C. Its importance lies in radical questioning and epistemic restraint, not in supplying a ready-made later doctrine.

Workbook MCQ 04

Early Upanishads are best understood as:

- A. post-Gupta Puranic compilations
- B. purely secular court manuals

- C. anti-Vedic tracts from outside shruti
- D. part of the Vedic corpus that redirects attention toward knowledge, self and release

Answer: D. They remain within shruti even while transforming the meaning of ritual and authority.

Workbook MCQ 05

Which feature most strongly supports the statement that the Upanishads do contain parabolic or narrative teaching?

- A. dialogues, analogies and story-based instruction
- B. temple ground-plans
- C. merchant guild charters
- D. Mauryan cave donations

Answer: A. Narrative pedagogy is a real feature of early Upanishadic instruction.

Workbook MCQ 06

The best statement about the second urbanisation as a philosophical background is that it:

- A. makes doctrinal study unnecessary
- B. widened the space for debate, renunciation and patronage without by itself fixing every doctrine
- C. ended Vedic learning immediately
- D. automatically produced one single heterodox ideology

Answer: B. It is enabling background, not an all-purpose explanation of content.

Workbook MCQ 07

In early Buddhism, anatman most directly means:

- A. denial of ethical causation
- B. worship of one universal soul
- C. denial of a permanent independent self
- D. denial of all conventional personhood

Answer: C. Buddhism denies a fixed self-substance, not the practical existence of persons and consequences.

Workbook MCQ 08

Abhidharma is best described as:

- A. a Vedic ritual manual
- B. a Persian translation movement
- C. a Jaina lay-ethics text
- D. a Buddhist analytic scholastic effort to classify teachings, states and paths

Answer: D. It signals the growth of systematic Buddhist analysis after the earliest teaching layer.

Workbook MCQ 09

Which statement about Madhyamaka is safest?

- A. It teaches emptiness as absence of inherent self-existing essence.
- B. It proves that nothing at all exists.
- C. It is a pure ritual school defending sacrifice.
- D. It teaches that fate alone governs the world.

Answer: A. Shunyata is a critique of inherent existence, not a claim that all reality is nullity.

Workbook MCQ 10

Yogacara is most safely introduced in Ancient History as:

- A. a doctrine of creator-God theism
- B. a Buddhist analysis of cognition or representation within Mahayana scholasticism

- C. a branch of Vedic sacrifice
- D. a medieval temple tax system

Answer: B. Topic 24 needs the bounded historical idea, not a caricature or optional-level expansion.

Workbook MCQ 11

Anekantavada in Jain philosophy means:

- A. denial of karma
- B. only ascetics can know anything
- C. many-sidedness of reality
- D. absolute scepticism about all truth

Answer: C. It insists that reality exceeds one rigid, one-sided verbal capture.

Workbook MCQ 12

Syadvada is best described as:

- A. atomism
- B. monastic taxation
- C. a creator-God doctrine
- D. qualified predication from a given standpoint or condition

Answer: D. It disciplines judgement through the language of conditional assertion.

Workbook MCQ 13

Which is the strongest secure Ajivika anchor?

- A. niyati in hostile sources plus rare inscriptional and patronage markers
- B. ownership of the six-school canon
- C. direct authorship of the Brahma Sutra
- D. a large surviving canonical library

Answer: A. Ajivikas are historically real, but the archive is thin and often adversarial.

Workbook MCQ 14

Charvaka / Lokayata is most strongly associated with:

- A. six-pramana scholasticism
- B. privileging perception and criticising many unseen ritual or afterlife claims
- C. karmic matter binding the soul
- D. the eightfold path

Answer: B. Perception and anti-supernatural critique are its safest markers.

Workbook MCQ 15

Why is astika = theist an unsafe formula?

- A. because the terms mean only political loyalty
- B. because all astika schools worship the same deity
- C. because historical criteria include Vedic authority or other-world assumptions, not simply belief in God
- D. because no source uses the terms at all

Answer: C. The labels are classificatory and polemical; they are not simple God/no-God badges.

Workbook MCQ 16

The neat list of six orthodox systems should be treated as:

- A. a Rigvedic-era canon
- B. a list fixed by Panini
- C. a Mauryan examination syllabus

- D. a later doxographic crystallisation applied to older uneven traditions

Answer: D. The traditions are old, but the neat grouped canon is later.

Workbook MCQ 17

The central Samkhya pair is:

- A. purusha and prakriti
- B. dravya and guna
- C. jiva and ajiva
- D. nirvana and samsara

Answer: A. Witness-consciousness and primordial nature are the foundational Samkhya distinction.

Workbook MCQ 18

Satkaryavada means that:

- A. universals are unreal
- B. the effect pre-exists in the cause
- C. fate is the only cause
- D. ritual alone produces all knowledge

Answer: B. This is Samkhya's best-known causation marker.

Workbook MCQ 19

Citta-vritti-nirodha is most directly linked to:

- A. Mimamsa
- B. Charvaka
- C. Yoga
- D. Vaisheshika

Answer: C. The formula expresses Yoga's project of disciplining the mind toward release.

Workbook MCQ 20

Nyaya is most distinctively remembered for:

- A. royal genealogy
- B. karmic matter
- C. temple sculpture
- D. pramanas, inference and structured debate

Answer: D. Nyaya's historical strength is public reasoning and proof.

Workbook MCQ 21

Vaisheshika is best described as the school of:

- A. categories / padarthas and atomistic realism
- B. exclusive devotional surrender
- C. the monastic Vinaya
- D. Persian political ethics

Answer: A. If Nyaya proves, Vaisheshika classifies what kinds of things exist.

Workbook MCQ 22

Purva Mimamsa is most closely associated with:

- A. materialist rejection of scripture
- B. Vedic injunction, dharma and ritual hermeneutics
- C. non-self
- D. emptiness of inherent existence

Answer: B. It is the major interpretive school of Vedic authority and action.

Workbook MCQ 23

The safest Ancient History description of Vedanta is:

- A. only Shankara's Advaita
- B. identical with Samkhya
- C. an Upanishad-and-Brahma-Sutra-centred exegetical field whose later sectarian systems should be clearly bounded
- D. only temple bhakti

Answer: C. Topic 24 owns the ancient textual base and must signpost later full doctrines as later developments.

Workbook MCQ 24

The Panini -> Katyayana -> Patanjali chain is important because it shows:

- A. grammar had no relation to philosophy
- B. Sanskrit replaced all Prakrits immediately
- C. language only mattered for poetry
- D. grammar became a rigorous intellectual technology with rule, critique and commentary

Answer: D. This chain underwrites exegesis, memory and verbal precision across schools.

Workbook MCQ 25

In the 2022 routed scholar-identification demand, Dignaga is correctly identified as:

- A. a Buddhist scholar
- B. a Pallava ruler
- C. a Jaina Tirthankara
- D. a Vedic rishi

Answer: A. Dignaga belongs to the Buddhist scholastic and logical tradition at the late-ancient boundary.

Workbook MCQ 26

Nathamuni is correctly identified as:

- A. a Charvaka founder
- B. a Vaishnava scholar associated with the Alvar hymn tradition
- C. an Ajivika ascetic
- D. a Madhyamaka monk

Answer: B. He is connected with collecting the Alvar hymns into the Nalayira Divya Prabandham.

Workbook MCQ 27

The safest caution when using pramana tables is that:

- A. all schools accepted the same six pramanas from the earliest Vedic age
- B. pramanas do not matter in Indian philosophy
- C. mature comparative ladders are useful, but should not be back-projected unchanged into the earliest phases
- D. only Nyaya used perception

Answer: C. Comparative clarity is valuable, but chronology still matters.

Workbook MCQ 28

Dependent origination differs from Ajivika niyati because dependent origination:

- A. denies causation completely
- B. is a theory of atomism
- C. proves one eternal soul

- D. explains conditioned arising rather than pure fate-driven inevitability

Answer: D. It is relational and conditional, not deterministic in the Ajivika sense.

Workbook MCQ 29

The sequence sutra -> bhashya -> vritti -> tika most strongly indicates:

- A. a compressed-text tradition that invited commentary and school formation
- B. the end of debate
- C. purely political record-keeping
- D. total absence of oral teaching

Answer: A. Compression and commentary are key reasons why school identities deepen over time.

Workbook MCQ 30

Nalanda and Valabhi should be used in Topic 24 as:

- A. proof that every school lived in one university model
- B. important but evidence-bounded centres, not universal stand-ins for all ancient philosophy
- C. Vedic sacrificial villages
- D. exact founders of the six-school canon

Answer: B. They matter, but they cannot replace the diversity of institutions across traditions.

Workbook MCQ 31

Which closing statement best captures the significance of ancient Indian philosophy?

- A. It was only mystical withdrawal from society.
- B. It produced one unchanging orthodox doctrine.
- C. It created a plural argumentative civilisation marked by borrowing, polemic, proof and competing paths to liberation.
- D. It was only royal propaganda.

Answer: C. That line preserves plurality, institutions and the historical force of debate.

Workbook MCQ 32

Which topic most clearly lies outside the core owner boundary of Topic 24?

- A. Ajivika source criticism
- B. Panini's role in the language turn
- C. Nyaya's inferential structure
- D. full later Ramanuja-Madhva doctrinal elaboration

Answer: D. Later Vedantic system-detail should be signposted, not absorbed wholesale into this ancient-core package.

Remedial MCQs for common confusions

Remedial MCQ 01

Which statement about the Upanishads and the Puranas is safest?

- A. The earliest Upanishads are earlier than the Puranic compilatory world.
- B. All Puranas are earlier than the Upanishads.
- C. Neither belongs to textual history.
- D. Both were composed at one fixed date.

Answer: A. This is the exact chronological discriminator tested in the 2024 Prelims route.

Remedial MCQ 02

The Purusha Sukta should be used in Topic 24 mainly as:

- A. a Buddhist sermon
- B. a cosmic-sacrificial hymn that later thinkers could reinterpret, not a finished social philosophy textbook
- C. a Mimamsa commentary
- D. a complete medieval caste constitution

Answer: B. It is important, but over-reading it into a total later system is unsafe.

Remedial MCQ 03

The safest sentence about Mahayana is that it:

- A. began after the Gupta period only
- B. had nothing to do with monastic institutions
- C. grew through layered doctrinal and devotional expansions rather than one overnight break from all earlier Buddhism
- D. rejected the Buddha completely

Answer: C. A layered expansion model is historically safer than the crude "single schism" model.

Remedial MCQ 04

In Topic 24, shunyata should be explained as:

- A. proof of soul-substance
- B. creator-God doctrine
- C. denial of ethics
- D. absence of inherent independent existence

Answer: D. This guards against the common error of calling Madhyamaka nihilism.

Remedial MCQ 05

Why should Yogacara not be reduced to "simple solipsism"?

- A. Because it is a Buddhist analysis of consciousness and representation within a wider soteriological framework.
- B. Because it rejects all cognition.
- C. Because it is a Vedic ritual school.
- D. Because it is identical with Charvaka.

Answer: A. Ancient-history treatment should stay conceptually accurate and bounded.

Remedial MCQ 06

Which statement best corrects the misuse of anekantavada?

- A. It proves that no judgement is ever possible.
- B. It requires qualified, standpoint-aware judgement rather than careless contradiction.
- C. It denies karmic bondage.
- D. It abolishes truth.

Answer: B. Jain epistemic humility is disciplined, not chaotic.

Remedial MCQ 07

Which contrast is correct?

- A. Ajivika = eightfold path; Charvaka = karma-matter
- B. Ajivika = Vedic ritual; Charvaka = bodhisattva ideal
- C. Ajivika = niyati-heavy ascetic current; Charvaka = perception-centred materialist critique
- D. Ajivika = Upanishadic self-knowledge; Charvaka = Vaishnava bhakti

Answer: C. This is the cleanest way to prevent the two heterodox streams from being blurred together.

Remedial MCQ 08

Which distinction best separates Samkhya from early Vedanta?

- A. Samkhya alone uses Sanskrit.
- B. Samkhya alone values liberation.
- C. Samkhya alone uses dialogue.
- D. Samkhya is a purusha-prakriti dualism, whereas early Vedanta is an Upanishad-centred exegetical field around brahman and atman.

Answer: D. This is a much safer distinction than "one is spiritual and the other is not."

Remedial MCQ 09

Which pair is correctly matched?

- A. Purva Mimamsa - ritual hermeneutics; Vedanta - Upanishadic / Brahma-Sutra exegesis
- B. Purva Mimamsa - cave architecture; Vedanta - grammar
- C. Purva Mimamsa - atomism; Vedanta - non-self
- D. Purva Mimamsa - fate; Vedanta - skepticism

Answer: A. The Purva / Uttara Mimamsa distinction is one of the most testable owner-boundary lines in the topic.

Remedial MCQ 10

The cleanest shorthand for Nyaya and Vaisheshika together is:

- A. fate and ritual
- B. proof and ontology
- C. mythology and architecture
- D. devotion and renunciation

Answer: B. Nyaya foregrounds reasoning; Vaisheshika foregrounds what kinds of things exist.

Remedial MCQ 11

The best owner-safe sentence on Bhartrhari is:

- A. He founded Mimamsa.
- B. He fully belongs to the earliest Vedic phase.
- C. He signals a late-ancient / early-medieval philosophy-of-language threshold and should be treated as a bounded extension, not as the core body of Topic 24.
- D. He is irrelevant to philosophy.

Answer: C. That preserves usefulness without letting a boundary figure take over the package.

Remedial MCQ 12

The best structure for a GS-I answer on ancient Indian philosophy is:

- A. school list only
- B. only socio-economic background
- C. only a spiritual conclusion
- D. chronology -> concepts -> inter-school comparison -> source caution -> significance

Answer: D. That structure delivers both coverage and historical discipline.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved topic-specific MCQs

Objective answers without a secure local official key are labelled inferred, translated or adjacent exactly as required.

Verified PYQ 1 - Prelims GS-I 2024 Q58 (exact wording locally preserved)

Consider the statements:

1. There are no parables in Upanishads.
2. Upanishads were composed earlier than the Puranas.

Which statement(s) is/are correct?

Status: Official local Set-A question paper and official Series-A answer key were already validated in Topic 09. Official answer: **B, statement 2 only.**

Explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because early Upanishads teach through dialogues, stories, analogies and paradoxes. Uddalaka's teaching to Shvetaketu is a standard narrative-analogy anchor. Statement 2 is correct because the early Upanishadic corpus belongs to the later Vedic / early first-millennium BCE horizon, whereas the Puranas were compiled and expanded much later over long centuries. [LIMIT] Exact dates of individual Upanishads and Puranic layers remain debated, but the relative chronology tested here is secure.

Why this earns marks: It answers at the level of both statement logic and source chronology, which is exactly what the Prelims trap is testing.

Routed PYQ 2 - Prelims GS-I 2022 Q56 (faithful English rendering from locally preserved Hindi paper; official key unavailable locally)

Consider the following pairs:

1. Aryadeva - Jaina scholar
2. Dignaga - Buddhist scholar
3. Nathamuni - Vaishnava scholar

How many pairs given above are correctly matched?

Status: The local official paper page is preserved and was visually checked, but the accessible preserved question page is Hindi. The rendering above is faithful in content, not claimed as locally verified official English wording. No official local answer key is held.

Answer / route: Only two pairs are correct.

- Aryadeva is not a Jaina scholar in this route; he is a Buddhist thinker associated with the Madhyamaka tradition.
- Dignaga is correctly identified as a Buddhist scholar and later logician.
- Nathamuni is correctly identified as a Vaishnava scholar associated with collecting the Alvar hymns into the Nalayira Divya Prabandham.

Why this earns marks: It solves the exact conceptual demand honestly without inventing a missing official key or pretending that the English wording was locally preserved when it was not.

Adjacent PYQ 3 - GS-I Mains 2020 Q11 (adjacent owner route, verbatim demand preserved in Art and Culture owner)

Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the monuments and their art in India. Discuss. (250 words)

Status: This demand is owner-routed to Indian Art and Culture Topic 13, not to Topic 24. It is included here because a student preparing Topic 24 should still understand how philosophical concepts move outward into artistic form without collapsing art history into pure doctrine.

Model answer: [CLAIM] Indian monuments and art were not mechanically "designed by philosophy," but philosophical traditions strongly shaped their symbolic programmes, ritual use and visual logic. [NAMED EVIDENCE]

-> MECHANISM] Buddhist ideas of relic veneration, sacred presence and the path generated the stupa form, circumambulation and narrative reliefs. Jaina ideals of renunciation, tirthankara veneration and ordered cosmology informed cave shrines and later iconographic discipline. Brahmanical and Upanishadic-Vedantic currents shaped temple iconography through cosmic ordering, sacred axis, image as embodied divinity and the integration of dharma, artha, kama and moksha within sacred space. Bhakti and sectarian theology later deepened this logic through Shaiva and Vaishnava image programmes. [QUALIFICATION] Yet philosophy was never the sole cause: patronage, craft skill, materials, regional politics and donor communities also mattered. [VERDICT] Indian philosophy and tradition therefore shaped monument conception most strongly at the level of sacred meaning, symbolic programme and ritual use, while actual built form emerged through interaction with society, patronage and technology.

Why this earns marks: It links concept to monument without making the false claim that one doctrine mechanically "produced" one form.

Original solved Mains questions

Original Mains Question 1 - 10 marks - 150 words

How did early Upanishadic speculation transform the meaning of Vedic ritual without simply rejecting the Vedic world?

Model answer: [CLAIM] Early Upanishadic thought transformed rather than simply discarded the Vedic world. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] The Brahmanas and Aranyakas had already begun symbolic interpretation of sacrifice; the early Upanishads pushed this further by shifting prestige toward knowledge of brahman, atman, karma, rebirth and release. Dialogues such as Yajñavalkya's and the teaching of Uddalaka to Shvetaketu show that inner knowledge, not only outer performance, became central. [ANALYSIS] Ritual language was re-read rather than erased: sacrifice became interiorised, equivalence-seeking and philosophically charged. [LIMIT] This was not a total break. The Upanishads remain within shruti, and they do not uniformly denounce Vedic ritual. [VERDICT] The transformation therefore lies in redirection of authority from external efficacy alone toward reflective knowing and liberation while preserving continuity with the Vedic textual world.

Why this earns marks: It gives continuity plus change, names the transition texts and avoids the simplistic "anti-Vedic revolt" line.

Original Mains Question 2 - 10 marks - 150 words

Why must Ajivikas and Charvakas be studied with stronger source criticism than Buddhism or Nyaya?

Model answer: [CLAIM] Ajivikas and Charvakas require stronger source criticism because their internal archives survive far more poorly than those of Buddhism, Jainism, Nyaya or Mimamsa. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Ajivikas are known largely through hostile Buddhist and Jaina accounts, with rare hard anchors such as Mauryan cave patronage and the doctrine of niyati. Charvaka or Lokayata is preserved mostly through later doxographies and rival refutations, not through a secure foundational text. [ANALYSIS] This means historians often know these schools through the language of opponents, who may caricature determinism, hedonism or anti-ritual critique. [LIMIT] Source-poverty does not make the schools unreal. It simply lowers the confidence with which details should be stated. [VERDICT] Strong source criticism is therefore part of the actual content of these traditions, not an external methodological extra.

Why this earns marks: It explains not only that evidence is thin, but why that changes the form of historical judgement.

Original Mains Question 3 - 15 marks - 250 words

Discuss how the shramana challenge reshaped the intellectual field of ancient India without being reducible to urbanisation alone.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The shramana challenge reshaped ancient Indian thought by relocating debate from sacrificial centrality toward suffering, bondage, discipline, karma, selfhood and liberation, but this shift cannot be reduced to a simple by-product of urban growth. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Buddhism recast the human problem through dependent origination, impermanence and non-self. Jainism developed a rigorous soul-karmic bondage model alongside anekantavada and syadvada. Ajivikas were remembered for niyati, while materialist currents challenged scriptural and afterlife claims. These traditions flourished in a wider world of towns, trade routes,

kings, gana-sanghas and patronage, which made itinerant debate and renouncer communities more viable. [ANALYSIS] Urbanisation mattered because it widened audiences, donors and social mobility. Yet doctrines were not mechanically caused by commerce. Buddhist non-self, Jaina karmic materialism and Ajivika determinism are conceptually distinct responses to shared existential and social pressures. [QUALIFICATION] Nor did the shramana field annihilate the Vedic world; Mimamsa and Vedanta show strong Brahmanical philosophical continuities. [VERDICT] The shramana challenge is therefore best understood as an argumentative reconfiguration of ancient Indian thought within a changing social landscape, not as an economic reflex.

Why this earns marks: It combines context and doctrine, gives named evidence from multiple traditions and closes with a balanced causal qualification.

Original Mains Question 4 - 15 marks - 250 words

Compare Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Mimamsa and Vedanta as distinct answers to knowledge, world and authority.

Model answer: [CLAIM] These four schools answer different leading questions, which is why grouping them all as "orthodox philosophy" hides their real intellectual diversity. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Nyaya asks how truth-claims are established through pramanas such as perception, inference, comparison and testimony; its five-member inference turns proof into public method. Vaisheshika asks what kinds of things exist and builds a realist ontology through padarthas and atomism. Mimamsa treats Vedic injunction, dharma and ritual interpretation as the core problem, turning hermeneutics into philosophy. Vedanta re-centres inquiry on the Upanishads, brahman, atman and the Brahma Sutra, trying to synthesise a metaphysical-exegetical field. [ANALYSIS] Thus Nyaya privileges epistemic procedure, Vaisheshika ontological categories, Mimamsa textual-action authority and Vedanta ultimate reality through scripture. [QUALIFICATION] Later histories pair Nyaya with Vaisheshika and Mimamsa with Vedanta, but the pairings should not erase their distinct original emphases. [VERDICT] The comparison shows that ancient Indian philosophy was not one doctrinal bloc; even within the so-called orthodox field, proof, world, duty and ultimate reality were separately and rigorously argued.

Why this earns marks: It compares by problem-type rather than by memorised label and therefore produces analytical depth quickly.

Original Mains Question 5 - 20 marks - 250 words

Ancient Indian philosophy was a plural argumentative field rather than a single spiritual consensus. Examine.

Model answer: [CLAIM] Ancient Indian philosophy was indeed plural and argumentative; describing it as one spiritual consensus erases the very debates that made the tradition historically powerful. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] The Upanishads shifted authority toward self-knowledge and liberation but did so in internally diverse ways. Buddhism denied a permanent self and explained existence through dependent origination. Jainism defended real souls, karmic bondage and many-sided knowing. Ajivikas were remembered for niyati, while Charvaka challenged Vedic authority and unseen metaphysical claims. Among the astika schools, Samkhya offered purusha-prakriti dualism, Yoga disciplined mind toward release, Nyaya built public reasoning, Vaisheshika classified being, Mimamsa defended ritual-hermeneutic authority and Vedanta systematised Upanishadic metaphysics. [ANALYSIS] These are not variations of one identical spiritual message. They disagree about self, causation, proof, scripture and liberation. Yet the field is not chaotic: debate, commentary and institutions created shared argumentative rules. [QUALIFICATION] "Plural" does not mean every school was equally preserved; doxography and hostile sources create distortions. [VERDICT] Ancient Indian philosophy is therefore best described as an argumentative civilisation in which rivalry, borrowing and commentary produced long-lived intellectual plurality.

Why this earns marks: It uses range without becoming a list, and it ties plurality to actual points of doctrinal disagreement plus institutional form.

Original Mains Question 6 - 20 marks - 250 words

Trace the movement from late Vedic speculation to classical darshana systematisation, bringing out both continuity and rupture.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The movement from late Vedic speculation to classical darshana systematisation involved both continuity of vocabulary and rupture in emphasis, method and institutional location. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Vedic and later Vedic texts supplied categories such as rta, sacrifice, sacred speech and speculative questioning. Aranyakas and early Upanishads interiorised ritual and developed brahman, atman, karma, rebirth and moksha through dialogue and paradox. The shramana field then radicalised the debate: Buddhism reframed bondage through non-self and conditioned arising; Jainism through soul and karmic matter; Ajivikas through fate; materialists through perceptual critique. Over time, sutra traditions such as Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Mimamsa, Yoga and the Brahma Sutra compressed and systematised distinctive positions. Grammar, commentary and public disputation deepened the field further. [ANALYSIS] Continuity lies in long concern with order, duty, speech, liberation and knowledge. Rupture lies in new critiques of ritual centrality, sharper school identities and more technical epistemological and metaphysical debate. [QUALIFICATION] The process was uneven, and later six-school doxography can falsely tidy it up. [VERDICT] Ancient Indian philosophy thus moved from layered speculative beginnings to increasingly explicit schools without ever losing the marks of cumulative borrowing and contest.

Why this earns marks: It is chronological, comparative and source-aware, which is exactly what a long GS-I answer on this topic requires.

Workbook closing recap

- Start long answers with chronology, not with an isolated school list.
- Keep Vedic, Upanishadic, shramana and sutra phases distinct.
- Use at least one named thinker or text if time permits.
- Treat astika / nastika as historical classifications, not as theist / atheist labels.
- Use Ajivika and Charvaka with stronger source caution.
- Do not project later Vedanta backward into the earliest Upanishads.
- For comparison answers, organise by self, causation, pramana and liberation-path.
- For 2024 Q58, remember both parts: Upanishadic parables exist, and early Upanishads predate the Puranic world.
- For 2022 Q56, remember the pairing triangle: Aryadeva and Dignaga are Buddhist; Nathamuni is Vaishnava.
- End with plural argumentative civilisation, not with spiritual homogenisation.